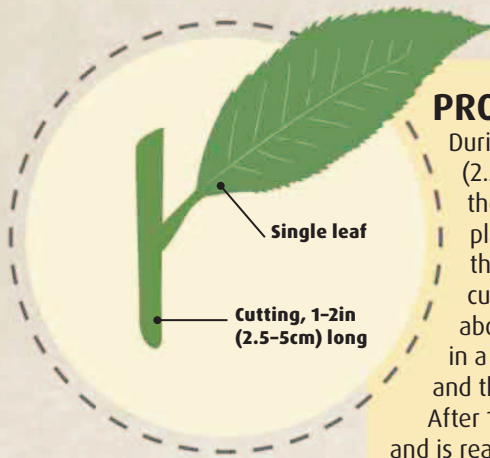
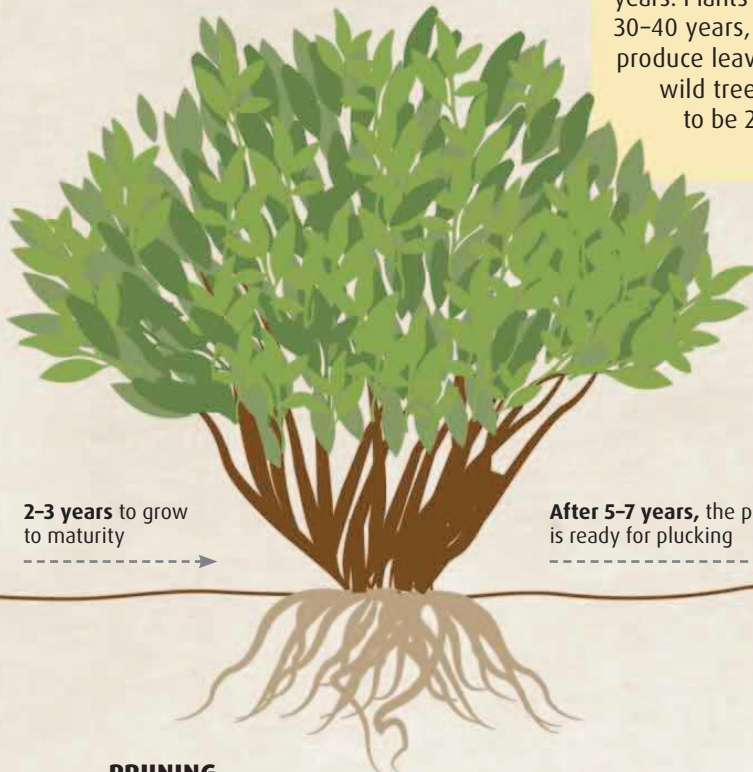




PROPAGATION FROM CUTTING

During the dormant, or dry, season, a cutting of 1-2in (2.5-5cm) with only one healthy leaf is taken from the middle portion of the primary shoot of the plant. (This is the shoot that grows directly out of the main trunk of the "mother plant.") The stem is cut diagonally, with a sharp knife, about 1/4in (5mm) above and 1in (2.5cm) below the leaf, then planted in a pot. Cuttings should be kept out of direct sunlight and the leaf sprayed with water daily.

After 12-15 months, the cutting will have grown roots and is ready to be transferred to a planting field. It will be another 12-15 months before it is harvested for the first time. Overall, the time from cutting to harvest is 2-3 years. Plants grown from cuttings have a life span of 30-40 years, while those grown from seeds can produce leaves for several hundred years. There are wild trees in China's Yunnan province estimated to be 2,000 years old.



2-3 years to grow to maturity

After 5-7 years, the plant is ready for plucking

PRUNING

The mature plant stands at 3-4ft (1-1.2m) high, and the goal is to have around 30 branches on a plant to maintain a good shape and height for plucking. Plants receive their first pruning after 2 years. This is done during the dormant season. Light pruning is done once a year thereafter, while heavy pruning, removing all the leaves and the secondary branches to encourage rejuvenation, takes place every 3-4 years.



PLUCKED BUD AND LEAVES

Hand-picked leaves should conform to industry standards: stems with 2-3 small leaves and tender buds are preferred for manufacture. This is considered a fine pluck.